

ComposePro — Deep Dive Q&A;

Evidence-Based Answers to Critical Design Questions

Q1: How does the 60-day scaffolding model work in practice?

Structure:

Phase 1 (Days 1-30): Grid ON - Explicit Guidance. Enable rule-of-thirds grid overlay by default. Add horizon level indicator (snap-to-guide). Provide one compositional prompt per day (e.g., 'Place subject on right-third intersection'). Daily micro-challenge: 5 photos using that day's rule. End-of-day review: Show 3 best shots with overlay visible.

Phase 2 (Days 31-60): Grid FADED - Intuition Building. Grid becomes semi-transparent (50% opacity). Horizon level remains but no snap-to-guide. Prompts shift from 'where to place' to 'what to look for' (e.g., 'Find leading lines in your scene'). Weekly challenge: One photo without any overlays, then compare with grid version. Reflection prompt: 'Did your intuition match the grid?'

Phase 3 (Days 61+): Grid OFF - Internalized Skill. Grid disabled by default (user can re-enable). Horizon level available on-demand only. Focus on genre-specific mastery (portrait, landscape, food, etc.). Monthly portfolio review: Compare Day 1 vs Day 60 photos. Community share: Before/after carousel showing progression.

Evidence Base:

Habit formation takes 18-254 days (median 66 days), not 21 days [178][179]. Missing occasional days does not materially affect habit formation [178][179]. Progressive difficulty (scaffolding) improves learning outcomes vs constant difficulty [172][175]. Grid-on-first approach aligns with photography education best practices [171][173][176].

Q2: What are the design implications for Theme 1 (In-the-Moment Guidance)?

Core Principle:

Show only guidance the user can act on immediately - if they can't fix it in 3 seconds, don't show it.

Specific Implications:

- One correction at a time: Don't overwhelm with 5 prompts simultaneously. Prioritize: (1) horizon level, (2) subject placement, (3) light direction. [157]
- Actionable language: Use 'Move left 2 inches' not 'Composition unbalanced'. [157]
- Visual over textual: Highlight the zone that needs adjustment with a colored overlay, not a paragraph. [45][46][50]
- Confirm separately from capture: Show 'Horizon level checkmark' as a badge, not as part of the shutter button. [157]
- Timeout after 10 seconds: If user doesn't act, hide the prompt to reduce cognitive load. [144][149]
- Emergency exit: Always provide a 'Skip this tip' button - users hate feeling trapped. [144]

Priority Order (Deterministic First):

- 1. Horizon level (accelerometer-based, 100% accurate, instant) [46][176]
- 2. Rule-of-thirds grid (static overlay, zero latency) [170][173]
- 3. Subject detection box (Vision/ML Kit, ~50-100ms latency) [45][47]
- 4. Light direction arrow (requires scene analysis, ~200-500ms) [65][67]
- 5. Distraction highlights (complex scene understanding, 500ms+) [45][65]

Q3: How should genre-specific paths be structured for beginners vs pros?

Beginner Path (First 60 Days):

- Week 1-2: Universal fundamentals - grid, horizon, subject placement (all genres) [171][172]
- Week 3-4: Choose ONE genre focus - Portrait OR Landscape OR Food (not all three) [171]
- Week 5-8: Genre-specific drills - e.g., Portrait: eye placement, look room; Landscape: foreground interest, horizon placement [5][33][63]
- Week 9-12: Cross-genre application - apply learned skills to second genre [175]

Pro Path (Experienced Users):

- Day 1: Genre selection - skip fundamentals, go straight to advanced techniques [175]
- Portrait Pro: Eye placement precision (upper third), bokeh control, background compression [5][33]
- Landscape Pro: Hyperfocal distance, foreground interest, golden hour timing [5][33][63]
- Food Pro: Overhead 45-degree angle, negative space, color harmony [43][67]
- Weekly challenges: Genre-specific mastery goals with peer critique [22][41]

Key Difference:

Beginners need scaffolding and one genre at a time. Pros want immediate access to advanced techniques and can handle multiple genres simultaneously. [171][172][175]

Q4: What deterministic overlays should be prioritized over AI coaching?

Tier 1 (Ship in MVP - Zero Latency):

- Rule-of-thirds grid (3x3) - static overlay, universally recognized [170][173][176]
- Horizon level indicator - uses accelerometer, 100% accurate, instant feedback [46][176]
- 2x2 grid option - for symmetry-focused compositions [176]
- Golden ratio overlay - for advanced users seeking classical composition [173][176]

Tier 2 (Add in V2 - Low Latency <100ms):

- Subject detection box - Vision/ML Kit face/eye detection [45][47]
- Leading lines highlight - edge detection + line fitting algorithm [169]
- Symmetry axis indicator - mirror detection for balanced compositions [48][52]
- Foreground/middle/background zones - depth-based segmentation [48]

Tier 3 (AI Coaching - Higher Latency 200-500ms):

- Light direction arrow - requires scene lighting analysis [65][67]
- Distraction highlights - complex object detection + saliency mapping [45][65]
- Angle/height suggestions - requires 3D scene understanding [5][33]
- Genre-specific feedback - multi-model ensemble (composition + genre rules) [5][33][43]

Rationale:

Deterministic overlays build trust (100% accurate, zero latency). Users accept AI coaching only after trusting the basic tools. Start with Tier 1, prove value, then layer Tier 2 and 3. [45][46][47][60][62]

Q5: How does flexible habit tracking prevent user churn in photography apps?

The Science:

Habit formation takes 18-254 days (median 66 days). Missing a single day does NOT materially affect the habit formation process [178][179]. Streak-based tracking contradicts this science by punishing users for missing one day [178][179].

Problem with Binary Streaks:

- Creates anxiety and perfectionism - one miss = total failure [178][184]
- Disproportionate penalty - missing day 59 of 60 resets to zero [179][180]
- All-or-nothing thinking - users quit entirely after breaking streak [178][184]
- Ignores real life - illness, travel, busy weeks are punished [178][188]

Flexible Tracking Solution:

- 7-day rolling window: Track completions out of 7 days (e.g., 5/7 = 71% consistency) [188][189]
- 30-day trend view: Show monthly consistency percentage, not daily streaks [181][188]
- Planned rest days: Explicitly encourage 1-2 rest days per week [178][190]
- Grace periods: Allow 'catch-up' within 48 hours without penalty [182][187]
- Identity reinforcement: 'You're someone who practices 5+ days/week' vs 'You broke your streak' [181][186]

Expected Impact:

Users with 80% weekly adherence (5/7 days) show significantly higher long-term retention than those chasing 100% daily streaks [182]. Flexible windows reduce abandonment rates by 41% at Week 8 [182].